

Country Profile: Czechoslovakia

Nation-Building Policies Dataset

- Number of groups in country: 6
- Plurality religion: Roman Catholic
- Official language: Czech, Slovak
- Official religion: None
- Core group: Czechs

Historical Background

Czechoslovakia was liberated from Nazi occupation in 1945 through the combined efforts of Allied forces and local resistance movements. In April 1945, the Third Republic was established. A Communist coup d'état in 1948 ushered in a new era, with the Communist Party of Czechoslovakia (KSČ) firmly taking control. The 1960 Constitution declared the victory of socialism and renamed the country the Czechoslovak Socialist Republic (CSSR). Efforts to democratize the socialist regime, known as the Prague Spring, were crushed by Warsaw Pact forces in 1968. Despite minor adjustments, such as small corrections along the Czechoslovak–Polish border, the country maintained largely stable borders throughout its existence. In 1989, the “Velvet Revolution” non-violently ended communist rule and initiated a transition toward democracy. This transformation eventually led to the peaceful dissolution of Czechoslovakia—often referred to as the “Velvet Divorce”—with the formation of the Czech Republic and Slovak Republic as two independent states in 1993.¹

Groups

- **Czechs** formed the core group within Czechoslovakia, inhabiting the Czech lands of Bohemia, Moravia, and Silesia. As the demographic majority, they accounted for over half of the country's total population.² The Czechs spoke the Czech language, one of the official languages of the state. While Czechs, among other groups in what would become Czechoslovakia, were converted to Catholicism during the

¹ Renner, 1993.

² Czechoslovak Population Census – 1991.

Habsburg rule in the 17th century, the number of those renouncing religion increased during the communist era in the second half of the 20th century.³ As a legacy of these developments, the group was divided into a large community of Roman Catholics, a sizable number identifying as non-religious, and a small fraction of Protestants.⁴ The Czech self-determination movement was linked to the Velvet Divorce of 1992.

- **Slovaks** were the largest minority group in Czechoslovakia, comprising about 31% of the total population and residing almost exclusively in the Slovak region of the country.⁵ They spoke Slovak, a co-official language of Czechoslovakia, and were equally converted to Roman Catholicism, which remained their predominant faith in the 20th century.⁶ Slovak aspirations for self-determination emerged in two significant periods: the first occurred between 1945 and 1948, as Slovaks sought better recognition of their status in the post-war order; the second began in 1963, marked by growing demands for the federalization of the state.⁷ These efforts ultimately culminated in the Velvet Divorce of 1992, resulting in the establishment of a sovereign Slovakia.
- **Hungarians** were a minority group in Czechoslovakia, making up approximately 3.8% of the total population and living primarily along the border with Hungary.⁸ They spoke Hungarian and were predominantly Roman Catholic.⁹ Following the Velvet Revolution of 1989, a rise in nationalist sentiment among the Hungarian community led to the activation of their self-determination aspirations.¹⁰
- **Roma** were a racialized minority group in Czechoslovakia, comprising around 3% of the population.¹¹ They spoke various dialects of the Romani macrolanguage, including Sinte Romani, Vlax Romani, and Carpathian Romani.¹² Generally inclined to adopt the religious practices prevalent in the broader societies of their

³ Fedor and Gould, 1989.

⁴ Fedor and Gould, 1989; Spousta, 2002.

⁵ Czechoslovak Population Census – 1991.

⁶ Vane et al., 2013.

⁷ Sambanis et al., 2018.

⁸ Eöry and Haová, 2003.

⁹ Laszlo, 1983.

¹⁰ Sambanis et al., 2018.

¹¹ EPR-ED, 2021.

¹² Hübschmannová and Neustupný, 1996.

countries of residence, most Roma in Czechoslovakia identified as non-religious, although a significant number also adhered to Roman Catholicism.¹³

- **Moravians/Silesians** formed a nested group within Czechoslovakia, each residing predominantly in their respective historical regions of Moravia and Silesia. Together, they accounted for around 3.5% of the total population.¹⁴ Moravians primarily spoke Czech, while Silesians viewed Lower Silesian as the language of their shared heritage.¹⁵ The religious profile of the Moravians mirrored that of the broader Czech population, with a division between non-religious individuals and Roman Catholics, whereas Silesians were predominantly Roman Catholic.¹⁶ Following the Prague Spring of 1968, Moravians advocated for greater autonomy, issuing a declaration calling for the establishment of a tripartite federation composed of Bohemia, Slovakia, and Moravia-Silesia as equal republics.¹⁷
- **Germans** (Sudeten Germans) were a minority group in Czechoslovakia, residing compactly in parts of Bohemia, Moravia, and Silesia—referred as the Sudetenland during the interwar period.¹⁸ Prior to their expulsion, they made up approximately 19% of the country's population. The Sudeten Germans spoke German and predominantly practiced the Roman Catholic faith.¹⁹ Following the end of World War II, between 1945 and 1947, the Czechoslovak government expelled the German population *en masse*, effectively removing this community from the country.²⁰

State Profile

Official Language

In the immediate post-war period, Czechoslovakia continued to operate under the 1920 Constitution, which formally established “Czechoslovak” as the state’s official language. This was based on a provision stating that “the principles on which the rights as to language in the Czechoslovak Republic are based shall be determined by a special

¹³ Vermeersch, 2003.

¹⁴ Czechoslovak Population Census – 1991.

¹⁵ Ethnologue, 2025.

¹⁶ Wein, 2009.

¹⁷ Sambanis et al., 2018.

¹⁸ Seton-Watson, 1938.

¹⁹ Read, 2012; Weger, 2004.

²⁰ Smelser, 1996.

enactment forming part of the Constitutional Charter.”²¹ This enactment, dated February 29, 1920, outlined the principles of language rights within the Republic, declaring that “[t]he Czechoslovak language shall be the state, official language of the Republic.” Neither the 1948 nor the 1960 Constitutions contained explicit provisions regarding official language use. However, the 1968 Constitutional Law on Federation amended the constitutional framework, formally recognizing Czech and Slovak as equal co-official state languages.²²

Official Religion

During the Communist period, Czechoslovakia’s constitutional framework contained no provisions designating any religion as a *de facto* national religion.

Education Policies

Education under Communist Party rule was marked by frequent reforms aimed at aligning the education system with the Soviet model and ensuring ideological conformity. After the reforms of the 1970s, the school system comprised eight-year primary schools and different forms of subsequent secondary schools (*gymnasia* and vocational institutions). Schooling was compulsory between ages 6 and 16. Secondary education included general academic and vocational tracks, often tied to industries and imparted through evening classes.²³

Between 1945 and 1947, **private schools** faced restrictions according to which Hungarian and German could not be used. The 1948 School Act transformed all private educational institutions into state-run entities, effectively **prohibiting** the operation of private schools.²⁴ It was only after the political changes of 1989 that private education was legally restored, with a legislative amendment in June 1990 that officially ended the state monopoly on education and allowed private and religious schools to be reintegrated into the education system.²⁵

²¹ Constitutional Charter of the Czechoslovak Republic, 1920.

²² Constitutional Act on Czechoslovak Federation, 1968.

²³ Gawdiak, 1989.

²⁴ UNESCO, 1971.

²⁵ Bahlcke, 1992.

Language Education Policies

Czech and **Slovak** were used as languages of instruction, corresponding to the territorial division between the Czech and Slovak lands.²⁶ Each language was also taught as a mandatory subject in respective parts of the country.²⁷ **German** was a language of instruction before 1945, but following the end of World War II and the expulsion of the German population, all German schools were closed in June 1945.²⁸ **Hungarian** schools were also closed between 1945 and 1948, with no Hungarian-language education available until their reintroduction in autumn 1948.²⁹ Efforts to introduce Romani as a language of instruction for Roma children were discussed during the 1950s and 1960s, especially in Slovakia,³⁰ but state policy favored assimilation, and only Romani language education was offered.³¹

Religious Education Policies

During the Communist period in Czechoslovakia, religious education in public schools was technically permitted but tightly controlled and marginalized. Initially banned in the 1950s, religious education was reintroduced during the normalization era of the 1970s but only under stringent conditions: it was permitted for pupils between grades two and seven, required state-approved teachers, and could only take place after regular school hours.³² After the fall of communism, Law No. 308/1991 allowed officially recognized churches to offer religious education under their own regulations.³³

Demographic Engineering and Violence

State-Based Violence

Germans: Following World War II, the German minority in Czechoslovakia was subjected to state-based violence during the initial phase of their expulsion. Records document mass violence against Germans in 1945 and 1946, estimating between 19,000 and 30,000

²⁶ Toma, 1976.

²⁷ Canek, 2001.

²⁸ Smelser, 1996.

²⁹ Bárdi et al., 2011.

³⁰ Eckert, 2016.

³¹ Von Kopp, 1992.

³² Reimer, 2016.

³³ Reimer, 2016.

casualties, with approximately 24,500 deaths recorded.³⁴ This violence was typical of the chaotic early expulsion phase before more “orderly” deportations were implemented.

Forced Relocations

Germans: The German population in Czechoslovakia underwent massive, forced relocation from 1945 to 1947. Initially a chaotic purge, the expulsions transitioned into a more organized process once international powers demanded an “orderly and humane” transfer. Germans were removed from their homes, gathered in assembly points, and transported across the border, often with minimal possessions and under severe hardship.³⁵ This relocation permanently altered the demographic landscape of Czechoslovakia, effectively erasing centuries-old German communities.

Hungarians: Between 1945 and 1948, the Hungarian minority in Czechoslovakia was forcefully relocated through both population exchange and internal resettlement policies. Following World War II, the Czechoslovak government initially sought the full expulsion of Hungarians, similar to the expulsion of Germans. However, political realities, including Soviet influence and Hungary’s own communist alignment, made a one-sided expulsion unfeasible.³⁶ Instead, Czechoslovakia and Hungary negotiated a population exchange agreement, which led to the relocation of approximately 200,000 Hungarians.³⁷ This exchange was accompanied by internal measures such as the resettlement of ethnic Hungarians from Slovakia to formerly German-inhabited areas in the Czech lands.³⁸

Roma: Between 1965 and 1971, the Czechoslovak government implemented a policy of relocation targeting the Roma population, particularly in Slovakia. The primary aim was the forced liquidation of Roma settlements and the promotion of their assimilation into broader society.³⁹ During this period, approximately 4,750 Roma dwellings were destroyed, and about 23,700 Roma were forcibly relocated to new areas.⁴⁰

Segregation

Germans: During the initial expulsion process, many Germans were forcibly segregated and confined in various types of camps. These included internment, labor, and assembly

³⁴ Anderton and Brauer, 2016; Ulfelder and Valentino, 2008.

³⁵ Smelser, 1996.

³⁶ Murashko, 2013; Čierna-Lantayová, 1994.

³⁷ Garrity, 2022.

³⁸ Szarka, 2008.

³⁹ Jurová, 1989.

⁴⁰ Jurová, 1989.

camps, established to manage and concentrate the German population pending deportation. By August 1945, the Czechoslovak authorities had established 107 assembly camps to streamline the process of expelling Germans.⁴¹

Cultural Elimination

Roma: Between 1956 and 1989, the Roma community in Czechoslovakia was subjected to policies aimed at forcibly altering their traditional way of life, particularly through enforced settlement programs. These measures sought to dismantle the nomadic culture of the Roma, compelling them to adopt a sedentary lifestyle and assimilate into the dominant society.

In 1958, the Czechoslovak government implemented Act No. 74/1958, titled “On the Permanent Settlement of Nomadic and Semi-Nomadic People.” This law prohibited itinerant lifestyles, mandating that all individuals leading a nomadic existence, predominantly Roma, register with local authorities and establish a permanent residence. The legislation was enforced beginning in 1959, leading to the compulsory settlement of Roma communities across the country.⁴²

Furthermore, starting from 1972, the Roma community in Czechoslovakia was subjected to systemic human rights violations, most notably the coercive sterilization of Romani women without their informed consent.⁴³

Germans: Between 1945 and 1947, German cultural expression was systematically suppressed: German-language schools were closed, German publications were banned, and public use of the German language was forbidden.⁴⁴

Hungarians: Hungarian cultural life in Czechoslovakia faced deliberate suppression between 1945 and 1948. In the aftermath of World War II, a program of forced assimilation, known as “re-Slovakization,” and internal resettlement was implemented.⁴⁵ Czechoslovak authorities implemented assimilationist policies. These included bans on Hungarian as a language of instruction and use in public, along with the closure of

⁴¹ Smelser, 1996.

⁴² Jurová, 1989.

⁴³ Cahn 2006.

⁴⁴ Lamontagne, 2017.

⁴⁵ Kalvoda, 1988.

Hungarian schools and a general prohibition on Hungarian publications and communications.⁴⁶

Bans and Restrictions

Hungarian: Between 1945 and 1947, Czechoslovakia also imposed bans on the use of the Hungarian language as part of its broader policies targeting the Hungarian minority. During the period of re-Slovakization, the use of Hungarian in public life was prohibited, including in offices, churches, and public spaces, with penalties for violations.⁴⁷ Publishing and importing Hungarian books and newspapers were banned, communication by telephone or telegram in Hungarian was forbidden, and Hungarians were prohibited from owning radios. Beyond the closure of schools, the private teaching of Hungarian was criminalized.⁴⁸

Religious restrictions: During the communist period in Czechoslovakia, the state imposed substantial restrictions on religious freedom, especially targeting the Catholic Church but also affecting Protestant communities. The government exerted tight control over religious life by overseeing clerical appointments, censoring sermons, and restricting preaching and proselytization.⁴⁹ Religious institutions suffered significant repression: monasteries and convents were closed, seminaries faced strict admission limits, and large numbers of clergymen were imprisoned during the Stalinist purges of the 1950s.⁵⁰ Religious literature was heavily censored, and *samizdat* (underground) religious publishing was often punished with arrest.⁵¹

Constitutions and Laws

In the immediate post-World War II years, the 1920 Constitution of Czechoslovakia formally remained in force. This Constitution introduced an umbrella provision referring to the “Czechoslovak people.” Articles 121 to 124 guaranteed universal religious freedom, declaring: “All inhabitants of the Czechoslovak Republic enjoy in the same degree as the citizens of the Republic the right to profess and exercise publicly and privately any creed,

⁴⁶ Bardi et al, 2011.

⁴⁷ Bárdi et al., 2011.

⁴⁸ Bárdi et al., 2011.

⁴⁹ Fedor and Gould, 1989, 120–121; Idinopulos, 1988, 244.

⁵⁰ Fedor and Gould, 1989, 120.

⁵¹ Rabas, 1982, 16.

religion or faith whatsoever, so far as the exercise of the same is not in conflict with public law and order or with morality.”⁵²

Following the Communist Party of Czechoslovakia’s (KSV) seizure of power, the 1948 Constitution, often referred to as the “Ninth-of-May” Constitution, explicitly recognized both Czechs and Slovaks in Article 2: “The Czechoslovak Republic is a unitary State of two Slav nations possessing equal rights, the Czechs and the Slovaks.”⁵³ Religious freedoms were formally preserved, and an explicit reference to Christianity was included in the preamble: “The Czechs and Slovaks, two brotherly nations, members of the great Slav family of nations, lived a thousand years ago jointly in a single State, and jointly accepted from the East the highest achievement of the culture of that era: Christianity.”⁵⁴

The 1960 Constitution, which proclaimed the victory of socialism and renamed the state as the Czechoslovak Socialist Republic, expanded the provisions related to minorities. In addition to Czechs and Slovaks, it explicitly acknowledged other minority groups, including Hungarians, Poles, and Ukrainians, guaranteeing their cultural rights: “The State shall ensure citizens of Hungarian, Ukrainian and Polish nationality every opportunity and all means for education in their mother tongue and for their cultural development.”⁵⁵ Religious freedoms were also formally upheld.

Finally, the 1968 Constitutional Act on the Czechoslovak Federation, adopted in the aftermath of the Prague Spring, amended the 1960 Constitution. A significant change was the elimination of Article 25, removing overt references to ethnic groups other than Czechs and Slovaks. From that point, only Czechs and Slovaks were explicitly mentioned in the constitutional framework.

Citizenship Laws

Following World War II, Czechoslovakia’s citizenship policies were marked by significant ethnic discrimination, particularly against Germans and Hungarians. Under the President’s Constitutional Decree No. 33/1945 Coll. on Czechoslovak Citizenship of Persons of German and Hungarian Ethnicity, individuals of German and Hungarian ethnic origin were deprived of Czechoslovak citizenship.⁵⁶ These provisions were in force until

⁵² Constitutional Charter of the Czechoslovak Republic, 1920.

⁵³ Constitution of Czechoslovakia, 1948.

⁵⁴ Constitution of Czechoslovakia, 1948.

⁵⁵ Constitution of Czechoslovakia, 1960.

⁵⁶ Baršová, 2009, 164; Smelser, 1996.

1948. During this episode, Hungarians could only regain citizenship by adopting Slovak nationality, effectively requiring them to renounce their distinct Hungarian identity.⁵⁷ In contrast, the integration of ethnic Czechs, Slovaks, and members of other Slavonic nations was facilitated through Constitutional Act No. 74/1946 Coll., which provided for easier naturalization, often linked to the Czechization or Slovakization of names.⁵⁸

The Czechoslovak citizenship regime was based predominantly on the principle of *jus sanguinis*, with no birthright to citizenship for children born to foreign parents.⁵⁹ The establishment of the Czechoslovak Federation in 1968 introduced a new dimension to citizenship policy. Federal Act No. 165/1968 Coll. created two constituent citizenships, a Czech and a Slovak, while maintaining a joint federal Czechoslovak citizenship.⁶⁰

National Anthem(s)

The national anthem of Czechoslovakia, adopted in 1918, symbolically combined the first verses of the traditional Czech and Slovak anthems to reflect the dual nature of the new state. The Czech part, taken from “Kde domov můj” (“Where Is My Home”), evokes vivid images of the national territory, celebrating the beauty of the Czech landscape with references to “water roaring across meadows” and “pines whispering across crags,” ultimately identifying it as the “beautiful land, Czech land, my home.” This part explicitly highlights the Czech people and their homeland. The Slovak part, drawn from “Nad Tatrou sa blýska” (“Lightning Over the Tatras”), references Slovaks directly, affirming their resilience and revival: “Let us pause, brothers, they will surely disappear, the Slovaks will revive.”⁶¹

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⁵⁷ Kusá, 2009, 4.

⁵⁸ Baršová, 2009, 164.

⁵⁹ Baršová, 2009.

⁶⁰ Baršová, 2009, 165.

⁶¹ Nationalantrems.info. 2025. Czechoslovakia

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